Planning and Conducting a User Test for Silka Application

1. Introduction

Silka is a mobile safety application designed to provide discreet emergency support for women in unsafe situations. The application is intentionally presented as a weather application while containing hidden safety functions such as Safe mode, trigger activation, and emergency alerts.

Because the app may be used during stressful moments, usability is highly important. Users should be able to complete key actions quickly and with minimal confusion. For this reason, a structured user test was planned and conducted to evaluate how first-time users interact with the prototype.

The purpose of this report is to describe the planning process, execution of the user test, findings, and design improvements identified through testing.

2. Planning the User Test

2.1 Test Goals

The user test was designed to answer the following questions:

- Do users understand the app interface without explanation?
- Does the weather disguise appear realistic?
- Can users find hidden settings independently?
- Can user's complete setup tasks successfully?
- Can users activate Safe Mode?
- What usability issues appear during use?

2.2 Test Tasks

To answer these questions, realistic tasks were selected for participants:

1. Open the application and describe what it appears to be.
2. Explore the main screen.
3. Find the hidden settings page.
4. Add an emergency contact.
5. Set a trigger phrase.
6. Activate Safe Mode.

7. Share final impressions.

These tasks were selected because they represent important first-time user interactions.

2.3 Participants

Two participants were selected for the test. Both participants were women, regular smartphone users, and had no previous experience using Silka. Female participants were considered relevant because the current concept of Silka is designed primarily as a safety application for women.

- **Participant 1:** Familiar with Android applications and common mobile navigation.
- **Participant 2:** General smartphone user with average technical skills.

3. Conducting the Test

Each participant completed the tasks individually. They were asked to use the app naturally without step-by-step help.

The think-aloud method was used; participants were encouraged to say what they were thinking while using the application. This helped reveal confusion, expectations, and decision-making.

During the sessions, the following were documented:

- Errors
- Hesitation
- Confusion points
- Time taken
- Workarounds
- General feedback

The tester mainly observed and avoided guiding users unless they became completely stuck.

4. Findings and Analysis

4.1 Positive Findings

- Both participants initially believed the application was a weather app.
- The interface was described as clean and simple.
- Users understood the idea of Safe Mode after discovering it.

- Both participants reacted positively to the discreet safety concept.

4.2 Problems Observed

- Weather app location search was not functional when tested.
- Both users struggled to locate hidden settings.
- One user expected visible settings from the main screen.
- Trigger phrase setup required explanation in the labels.

4.3 Patterns Across Users

The strongest repeated pattern was uncertainty around hidden functionality. While discretion supports safety, it also reduced discoverability for first-time users.

This showed a clear balance must be found between secrecy and usability.

5. Prioritized Improvements

High Priority

- Improve labels and wording for setup fields to reduce confusion
- Improve access flow to hidden settings
- Fix weather location search functionality

Medium Priority

- Improve first-time onboarding for new users
- Add clearer trigger phrase instructions and labels
- Improve guidance during initial setup process

Low Priority

- Minor visual refinements
- Faster navigation between screens

6. Reflection

The user test showed that the weather disguise worked well, because both participants first understood the app as a normal weather application. This was a positive result for the covert design goal. However, the test also showed that hidden safety functions need a careful balance. If the features are too hidden, first-time users may not understand how to access them. If they are too visible, the app may lose its discreet purpose.

The test was valuable because it revealed practical usability issues, especially with hidden settings, labels, and setup instructions. These findings helped identify what should be improved before the next version of the prototype.

7. Conclusion

The user test helped confirm what worked well in the prototype and what needs improvement. The next version of Silka should focus on clearer labels, better setup guidance, and a more usable hidden settings flow while keeping the app discreet.